

KEY EVENTS

The Ottoman Empire expanded rapidly after it was formed, as the sultans set out to gain new territory for Islam, and also wealth to reward their followers.

1453
Mehmed II conquers Constantinople. The Byzantine Empire ceases to exist.

1514
Selim I invades northern Iraq and takes over most of the Middle East.

Selim I mosque, Istanbul



1571
Defeat at Battle of Lepanto stops Ottomans from expanding further west.

1914
Ottomans join World War I on the side of the Central Powers.

1923
The Ottoman Empire is dissolved and the Republic of Turkey is formed.

1300

1354
Ottoman armies cross into Europe at Gallipoli.

1369
Ottomans capture Edirne, which becomes their capital.



Edirne mosque

1529
Army of Suleiman I besieges the Austrian capital, Vienna, but fails to conquer it.

1566
Suleiman I dies in Hungary. The Ottomans would advance no further into Europe.

1538
Ottoman navy wins control of the eastern Mediterranean at the Battle of Preveza.

1683
The Ottomans are defeated at the Battle of Vienna, starting the decline of the empire.



Suleiman I in battle

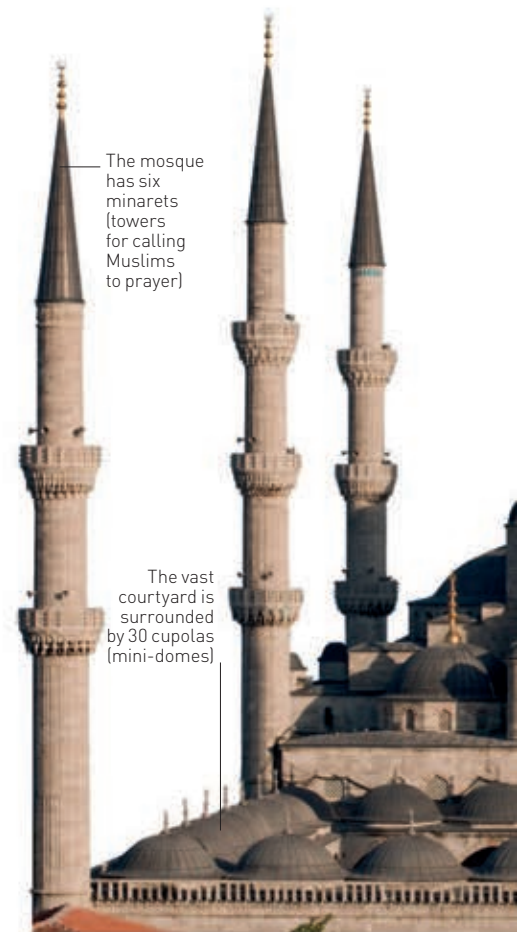
2000



Modern Turkish flag

The Ottoman Empire

The Ottoman Empire was one of the biggest and longest-lasting empires in history. It was founded in the 14th century by Osman, a Turkish *ghazi* (Islamic warrior). Two hundred years later, the empire stretched over three continents: Africa, Asia, and Europe. It was ruled over by a series of powerful sultans, with the help of armies of slave-soldiers.



TOPKAPI PALACE
Built in 1460 for Mehmed II, Topkapi was the main palace of the sultans for 400 years.

POWERFUL SULTANS

The Ottoman Empire was ruled by descendants of the same family for 600 years. The sultans formed strong governments, and life under Ottoman rule was mostly peaceful and safe for ordinary citizens.

- OSMAN I (GAZI) (c.1258–1326)**
The founder and first sultan of the Ottoman Empire. A successful military general who extended Ottoman territory throughout his 27-year reign.
- MEHMED II (THE CONQUEROR) (1432–81)**
A great military leader, he captured Constantinople and conquered territories in Anatolia and the Balkans.
- SELIM I (THE GRIM) (1470–1520)**
Selim came to power after a civil war. He killed his brothers, and others who might have had a claim to the throne after his death, so that his chosen son, Suleiman, could become sultan.
- SULEIMAN I (THE MAGNIFICENT) (1494–1556)**
One of the greatest sultans. During his 46-year reign, the Ottoman Empire became a world power. Suleiman's reign was also a time of great achievements in literature, poetry, art, and architecture.
- ABDULMECID I (1823–61)**
Responsible for an ambitious reform of the army, schools, and other institutions. Abdülmecid hoped this reform would make the declining empire competitive with other European countries.

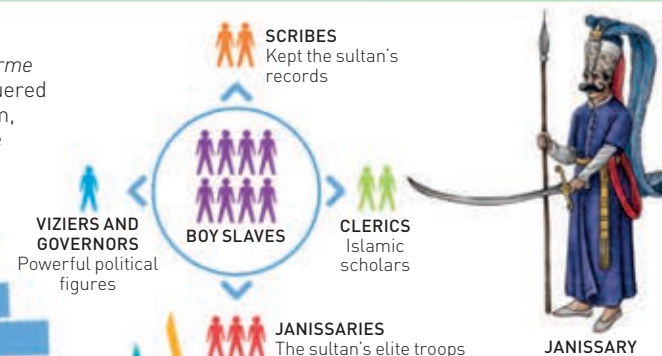


SULEIMAN I THE MAGNIFICENT

THE SULTAN'S LOYAL MEN

The Ottomans operated a system called *devshirme* (gathering), in which Christian boys from conquered countries were made slaves, converted to Islam, and taught total loyalty to the sultan. They were then trained to do important jobs within the sultan's household and army.

WHEN SULTAN MEHMED II TOOK POWER, HE PUT ALL HIS BROTHERS TO DEATH, TO PREVENT PLOTS AGAINST HIM



MARK OF THE SULTAN

The *tughra* was the personal seal of the Ottoman emperors. All important documents, coins, and letters from the sultan carried a symbol, which was different for every ruler. The *tughra* was based on Arabic calligraphy. It was designed at the beginning of the sultan's reign and drawn by the *nişancı* (court calligrapher) on to court papers.

